Bridging Generations through Cultural Exchange: A Mixed-Method Prospective Study Examining the Effects of a Bidirectional Culturally Based Intergenerational Program on Wellbeing and Cultural Identity

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Background

Social isolation (SI) among older adults is a growing public health concern in Canada, contributing to declining mental well-being, reduced mobility, and increased healthcare use.[3] As more older adults age in place, community-based approaches that promote social connection, mobility, and independent living are needed.[4] Simultaneously, many immigrant youth experience **cultural identity disconnect**, and **limited intergenerational engagement opportunities**.[2]

Existing programs improve social outcomes and wellbeing among older adults but remain **unidirectional** and rarely address youth cultural identity or reciprocal cultural exchange. Little is known about the impacts of **bidirectional** culturally based intergenerational programs on older adult wellbeing, youth cultural identity, and healthcare utilization.

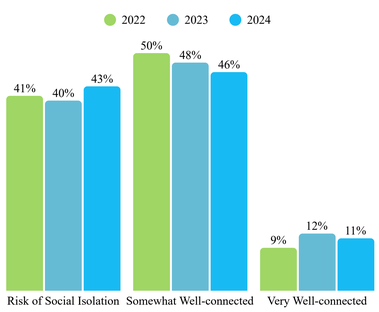

Figure 1. Prevalence of SI Among Older Adults (2022-2024). Approximately 40-43% of older adults were identified at risk of SI, where only 9-12% report being very well-connected.[3]

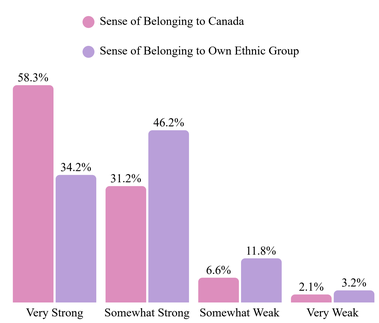

Figure 2. Sense of Belonging Among Second-Generation Immigrant Youth in Canada. Second-generation youth exhibit stronger identification with Canada than with their ethnic heritage, indicating a potential disconnect in identity.[1]

Study Objectives

1. Develop and implement a multidimensional, **bidirectional** culturally based intergenerational program to foster social connection, mobility, and cultural exchange.
2. Assess the effects of program on older adult social isolation, mental wellbeing, and mobility, and on youth cultural connectedness.
3. Explore the potential preventative and healthcare implications.

References

Scan the QR code for our reference list.

Methods

The **mixed-method prospective study** measures physical, mental, and social outcomes while capturing participants' lived experiences of **cultural connectedness** and **intergenerational relationships**. Preliminary needs assessments gauge interest, feasibility and identify community needs for a culturally based intergenerational program.

- 12 Older Adults (65+).
- 12 Youth (15-24 Years).

- Older adults of various cultural origins.
- Youth must pass a VSC & training modules.

- Seniors without cognitive decline (e.g., dementia) who do not have dedicated caregivers due to safety reasons.
- Youth who **are not** first or second-generation immigrants.

- London, Ontario

- Recruitment will occur through advertisements, cultural organisations, door-to-door canvassing and social media.

- Two-hour meetings.
- Three times a week.
- Eight-month program.

- Provides older adults with transportation to programming at community centres and parks.

Participant surveys will assess demographics and program interests to pair participants into **intergenerational dyads**. Each session will include physical, social, and cognitive activities designed to reduce SI, promote mobility, and intergenerational engagement with older adults, leading **cultural knowledge-sharing activities**.

Quantitative Data

- For older adults, assess social isolation (SI), mental well-being, and mobility, with a focus on fall risk.
- Measure **SI** using the **Lubben Social Network Scale** and open-ended questions.
- Assess **mobility** using the **Short Physical Performance Battery**.
- Evaluate **mental well-being** through the **Warwick-Edinburgh Mental Well-being Scale.**
- **Youth outcomes** are measured using the modified **Cultural Connectedness Scale**.
- Data will be analysed using **descriptive statistics** and **repeated-measures analyses** to assess changes over time.

Qualitative Data

- Collected through **open-ended survey responses and reflective feedback** to explore participants' experiences of intergenerational interaction, cultural exchange, and perceived program benefits.
- Data will be **analysed thematically**.

Assessments will be conducted at baseline, four months, and eight months.

Healthcare-system-level effects will be examined through wait-time data and post-program hospital readmissions.

Limitations

- While our program accommodates seniors with physical disabilities, mobility aids, and care staff, we cannot support those with **cognitive decline**, such as dementia, without dedicated caregivers for safety reasons.
- The duration and high participation demands may lead to **inconsistent attendance** or dropout among both older adults and youth. This may introduce bias and limit internal validity.
- Use of **convenience sampling** and a **small sample size** limits the ability to ensure representation across all cultural groups. This may increase the risk of selection bias and limit statistical power.

Expected Results

By addressing social isolation in older adults and youth cultural disconnect, this study anticipates meaningful **reductions in social isolation and fall risk** among older adults, alongside **stronger cultural identity** among youth. Older adults are anticipated to report improved mental wellbeing, and mobility. Youth would show higher cultural identity scores and positive intergenerational experiences. Together these improvements may **reduce burden on healthcare**.

Discussion

This research addresses a critical gap in the Canadian context, where **bidirectional knowledge-exchange** and holistic benefits to both groups are often overlooked within intergenerational programs as a measure of impact. This model seeks to change the framing of older adults as passive care recipients into engaged peers with purposeful teaching roles. Collectively, expected outcomes of this model are:

- Establishment of a validated framework for future intergenerational programming with a focus on **bidirectional exchange**, holistic programing and inclusivity in diverse Canadian communities.
- **Cultural empowerment** for young adults.
- Enhanced QOL and wellbeing of older adults resulting in reduced burden on the healthcare system.
- Improved intergenerational relationships and deconstruction of **internalized ageism** among both cohorts.

Equity, Diversity, Inclusion

This program promotes inclusive and **equitable access** for immigrant older adults and youth, two groups that face structural barriers to wellbeing. Centred on cultural exchange and lived experience, the program values the diverse identities, languages and traditions participants bring and recognises older adults as **knowledge holders**, providing opportunities for cultural knowledge to be passed down to youth. A bidirectional mentorship design ensures inclusivity by positioning both groups as **active contributors.**
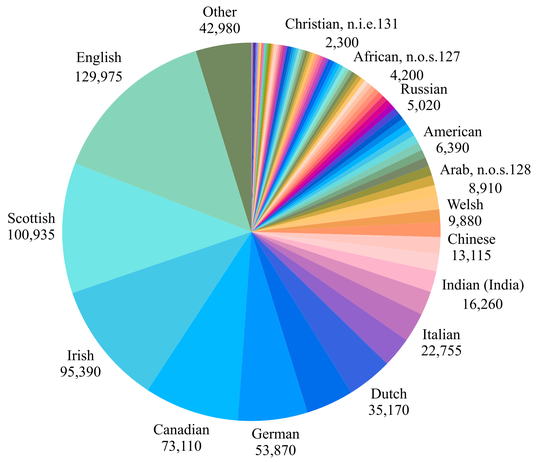
Figure 3. Ethnic or cultural origin for the London population in 2021
Data from the 2021 Statistics Canada Census illustrate the ethnic and cultural diversity of London's population. The distribution highlights the multicultural composition of the community, informing the development and feasibility of culturally based intergenerational programming within the study.[5]